for raw materials and markets justified imperialism, while industrial technologies made imperial conquests easier. Steamships were crucial, for example, to the British victory over the Chinese in the Opium Wars, and railways played a decisive role in the American expansion west and the Russian expansion east and south. Indeed, entire imperial projects were shaped around the construction of railroads such as the Trans-Siberian and Trans-Caspian Russian lines, the German dream of a Berlin–Baghdad railway, and the British dream of building a railway from Cairo to the Cape.[3]

Nevertheless, most polities didn't join the burgeoning industrial arms race in time. Some lacked the capacity to do so, like the Melanesian chiefdoms of the Solomon Islands and the Al Thani tribe of Qatar. Others, like the Burmese Empire, the Ashanti Empire and the Chinese Empire, might have had the capacity but lacked the will and foresight. Their rulers and inhabitants either didn't follow developments in places like northwest England or didn't think they had much to do with them. Why should the rice farmers of the Irrawaddy basin in Burma or the Yangtze basin in China concern themselves about the Liverpool–Manchester Railway? By the end of the nineteenth century, however, these rice farmers found themselves either conquered or indirectly exploited by the British Empire. Most other stragglers in the industrial race also ended up dominated by one industrial power or other. Could something similar happen with AI?

When the race to develop AI gathered steam in the early years of the twenty-first century, it too was initially spearheaded by private entrepreneurs in a handful of countries. They set their sights on centralising the world's flow of information. Google wanted to organise all the world's information in one place. Amazon sought to centralise all the world's shopping. Facebook wished to connect all the world's social spheres. But concentrating all the world's information is neither practical nor helpful unless one can centrally process that information. And in 2000, when Google's search engine was making its baby steps, when Amazon was a modest online bookshop, and when Mark Zuckerberg was in high school, the AI necessary to centrally process oceans of data was nowhere at hand. But some people bet it was just around the corner.

Kevin Kelly, the founding editor of *Wired* magazine, recounted how in 2002 he attended a small party at Google and struck up a conversation with Larry Page. 'Larry, I still don't get it. There are so many search companies.